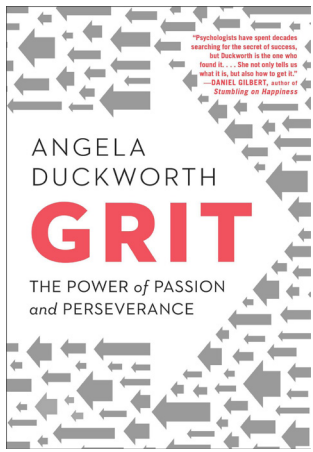




GRIT

The Power of Passion and Perseverance

ANGELA DUCKWORTH

The Big “So What”



Grit has been found to be a stronger predictor of high-achievement than intelligence, talent and other personality traits. In this book, Duckworth explains why this is so and how we can cultivate grit in both ourselves and others to accomplish more in life.

Introduction



Grit is the combination of passion (a deep, enduring knowledge of what you want) and perseverance (hard work and resilience). It has been found to reliably predict whether military recruits graduate from rigorous elite training programs, whether salespeople stay in their jobs, whether high-school students graduate on schedule and whether adults earn their graduate degrees.

Grit = Passion + Perseverance



Over the years, Duckworth has studied grit through experiments, empirical research and interviews with “grit paragons” (people who exemplify grit). In this book, she explains **why grit matters**, **how it relates to other success factors** and **how we can develop grit**.

Why Grit is Important



✗ Various research studies have proven that talent and intelligence alone don't predict success. In fact, they can be dangerous when over-emphasized.

KEY QUOTES

“What we eventually accomplish may depend more on our passion and perseverance than on our innate talent.”

“It was this combination of passion and perseverance that made high achievers special. In a word, they had grit.”

“Apparently, aptitude did not guarantee achievement.”

- Talent can hinder performance when people feel they needn't work as hard or try to hide their weaknesses instead of addressing them. People who believe they lack talent may also give up without discovering what they're truly capable of achieving.
- Aptitude tests are poor measures of true potential. Duckworth's student was assessed (based on aptitude tests) to be inadequate for advanced math classes, yet he excelled and went on to become a rocket scientist. West Point's "Whole Candidate Score" was designed to shortlist cadets with the propensity to master the required skills, yet only 20% of the shortlisted recruits graduated. Grit turned out to be a much stronger predictor of whether cadets would graduate.

 In the end, talent is only important if you put in effort. In fact, effort is doubly important to move from talent to achievement:



- You must put in effort to hone your natural talents into tangible skills through practice and improvement. You must also put in effort to apply those skills to solve real-world problems to attain achievement. Grit is vital for achievement as it helps to sustain effort. [Note: this theory is about the inner psychology of achievement and doesn't address external factors like luck or opportunities.]
- For example, celebrity potter Warren MacKenzie dabbled with many artistic interests from painting to textile design before focusing on pottery. His first 10,000 pots were the most difficult. However, once he developed the required skills, he was able to produce good pots more easily, and could focus his efforts on creating masterpieces for more people.
- In his study of competitive swimmers, sociologist Dan Chambliss found that great genes or inborn physical features only play a small role in excellence. If you did a time-lapse video of a swimmer's life, you'd find that the real results come from a series of mundane activities like daily training and conditioning.

 Most of us value hard work. Yet, we tend to have a talent-bias, i.e. we're positively biased toward natural talent.

KEY QUOTES

"What we accomplish in the marathon of life depends tremendously on our grit—our passion and perseverance for long-term goals. An obsession with talent distracts us from that simple truth."

"Skill is only developed by hours and hours and hours of beating on your craft."

"With effort, talent becomes skill and, at the very same time, effort makes skill productive."

*"In doing something over and over again, something that was never natural becomes almost second nature...it doesn't come overnight."
-John Irving*

*"Greatness is many, many individual feats, and each of them is doable."
- Dan Chambliss*

- Naturals vs strivers. People tend to believe “naturals” with musical talent are more likely to succeed than “strivers” who work hard to make their mark. Investors are also more likely to back a “natural entrepreneur” than a “striver entrepreneur”.
- When we see people performing effortlessly, we instinctively attribute it to their special talents. After all, (i) the mystery of natural-born talent is much more exciting than the mundanity of hard work, and (ii) we won’t feel as bad about our own lack of achievements if we can blame it on our lack of magical talent.



Understanding Grit

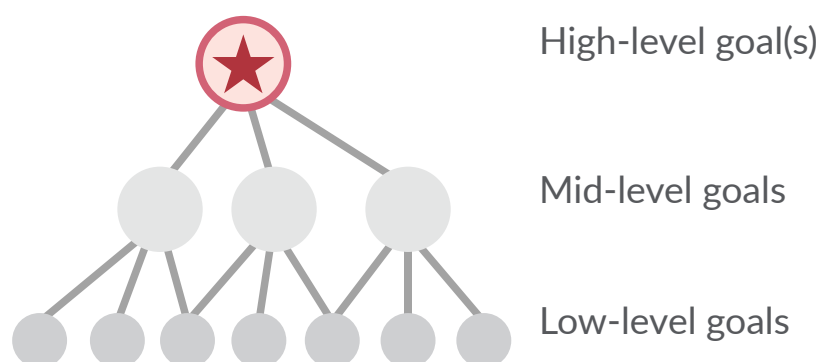


Grit is *not* about the intensity of your passion or enthusiasm. It’s about moving in a direction with consistency and endurance. It’s like having a clear inner compass that guides all your decisions and actions. Gritty people ponder their purpose daily, feel excited about every small step in the right direction, and keep refining their path until they’re where they want to be.

- In the book, Duckworth shares the Grit Scale—it comes with 10 self-assessment questions that measure how easily you get distracted by new projects/goals/interests, whether you work hard, finish what you begin and overcome challenges/setbacks. Your grit score is a snapshot of how you see yourself now; it will change over time.



Aligning your goals. All of us have a hierarchy of goals. Low-level goals are concrete, specific, and the means to an end, like items on our weekly to-do list. As you move up the hierarchy, your goals become more abstract and important.



- Your top-level goal is your end-goal or life-purpose. Hall of Fame pitcher Tom Seaver seeks to be “the best I possibly can day after day, year after year.” Duckworth seeks to “use psychological science to help kids thrive”.

KEY QUOTES

“Mythologizing natural talent lets us all off the hook. It lets us relax into the status quo.”

“Enthusiasm is common. Endurance is rare.”

- Gritty people (i) stick to their high-level goals consistently and (ii) align their goals at all levels. In short, grit is not about sticking to every goal to the bitter end. It is about being clear and loyal to your top-level goal and adjusting your low-level goals to support that end goal. In fact, you should change your low-level goals regularly to make them more viable, effective and/or congruent with your high-level goals.
- You can use these 4 steps to prioritize and align your goals:
 - (i) List down 25 goals.
 - (ii) Reflect on them and choose just 5 top-priority goals. Consider which of these inter-related goals are means-goals vs end-goals, and which ones are the most important to you.
 - (iii) Intentionally avoid the other 20 goals that you didn't select. These will be your biggest distractions.
 - (iv) Define your single inner compass. Ask yourself: to what extent do your key goals serve a common purpose? Use your top-level goal as a compass to guide/align the lower-level goals.



Grit Can Be Developed



Nature vs nurture. Every aspect of our human traits comes from both genes and life experiences. Grit is no different.

- Even traits like height (which may seem to be 100% genetic) can be changed in 1 generation due to nutrition, modern medicine, clean air and water. Talents, personality traits and grit are also an outcome of both nature and nurture.
- All human traits are polygenic, i.e. they're influenced by multiple genes. Hence, there's no such thing as a "grit gene".



We change with age. The grittiest adults were found to be around 70 or older, while the least gritty were in their 20s.

- There are 2 plausible explanations: the older people lived in a different cultural era with different values and/or they developed grit as they matured. There's inadequate scientific data to draw a firm conclusion at this point.

KEY QUOTES

"The more unified, aligned, and coordinated our goal hierarchies, the better."

"Time and energy are limited. Any successful person has to decide what to do in part by deciding what not to do."

"Necessity is the mother of adaptation."

- Duckworth believes that both factors play a part, with life experiences playing the bigger role. Over time, we learn things that we didn't previously know, e.g. realizing we have the ability to overcome setbacks. At other times, we're simply forced by circumstances to learn to act differently, e.g. when we get a new job, become a parent, or undergo a life-changing event.



Becoming grittier. Research suggests 4 “psychological assets” behind grit. Each of these components can be developed by yourself (from inside-out) or with external help (from outside-in).

- Interest: loving what you do;
- Practice: focusing on improvement no matter what;
- Purpose: believing strongly that your work matters to yourself and to others. This usually happens only after years of cultivating your interest and honing your abilities from practice; and
- Hope: believing that you can work things out and overcome your challenges. Hope works hand-in-hand with all 3 components above to determine how you respond to failures—if you get up and keep going, or stay down and be defeated.

In the next 2 sections, we'll break down how you can develop grit from inside-out and outside-in.

Developing Grit From Inside Out



Many successful people have advised us to follow our passion in choosing our career. Indeed, people who are interested in their jobs are much more satisfied with their work, perform better, stay longer in their jobs and are happier with their lives in general.



However, passion is *not* inborn; passion is cultivated over time.

- Grit paragons didn't start by finding the perfect job and falling crazily in love with it. Nor did they discover their passion in a magical, fireworks-filled moment. Instead, they spent years exploring different interests before focusing on one area. As they practiced and honed their skills, they also developed a deeper understanding and appreciation of their craft until it became a burning passion and a calling.

KEY QUOTES

“Passion begins with intrinsically enjoying what you do.”

“What ripens passion is the conviction that your work matters.”

“At various points, in big ways and small, we get knocked down. If we stay down, grit loses. If we get up, grit prevails.”

“The directive to follow your passion is not bad advice. But what may be even more useful is to understand how passions are fostered in the first place.”

“Passion for your work is a little bit of discovery, followed by a lot of development, and then a lifetime of deepening.”

- To cultivate deep interest , there are several core ingredients:
- (i) *Age*. Most people only start to cultivate specific vocational interests around middle school.
- (ii) *Real-life triggers*. You can't predict exactly what will interest you. Any random event may spark your interest, though you'd probably be too absorbed in the moment to realize it.
- (iii) *A period of interest development*. For an interest to take root, it must catch your attention repeatedly.
- (iv) *Supportive people*. Positive feedback and stimulation (from parents, coaches, peers etc.) help your interest to thrive.



Discovering your Interests



In the initial stages, most people learn and practice something for fun, not to develop a life-long career.

- At this phase, interest is best nurtured through fun, exploration and autonomy. If you push a beginner too hard, you may end up killing the fledging interest.
- For example, New York Times puzzle editor Will Shortz was introduced to puzzles from young by his mum, a writer and puzzle lover. When he started to create his own puzzles, his mum taught him how to submit his puzzles for sale, and he sold his first puzzle at the age of 14. Amazon's founder Jeff Bezos loved to tinker with solutions since young. Instead of scolding or discouraging him, his mum listened to his ideas and even helped to buy parts so he could assemble his prototypes.



Although gritty people typically discover their interest through trial and error, they don't make many career changes once they've identified their passions/interests.

- It's ok to have multiple hobbies and to switch them regularly. However, if you keep switching occupations, you'll never progress beyond a passionate newbie to master anything of real value.

KEY QUOTES

"Rush a beginner and you'll bludgeon their budding interest. It's very, very hard to get that back once you do."

"The reality is that our early interests are fragile, vaguely defined, and in need of energetic, years-long cultivation and refinement."

"Doing one thing better and better might be more satisfying than staying an amateur at many different things."

"For the beginner, novelty is anything that hasn't been encountered before. For the expert, novelty is nuance."

- Grit paragons don't get bored with their craft because they keep discovering fascinating *nuances and distinctions*. An art expert can appreciate the fine details between the different art pieces while a novice can't, and such deep mastery can be extremely fulfilling.



If you don't have a passion yet, start by discovering your interests:

- *Reflect* on questions like: What do I tend to think about the most? What do I really care about? What makes me feel alive? What do I find unbearable?
- Once you have a rough idea, *start experimenting* with different things in that general direction. Give yourself some time to do trial and error in each area, bearing in mind you'll need repeated exposures to develop an interest. Keep exploring, discovering and seeking out mentors until certain options stand out.



Deepening Through Practice



The term "deliberate practice" was coined by cognitive psychologist Anders Ericsson. He found that experts *became outstanding not just from lots of practice, but how they practiced*. Specifically:

- They set a *stretch goal*, zooming in on a specific weakness or area for improvement.
- They *practice with full attention* (often by themselves) with 100% focus on reaching the stretch goal.
- They seek *immediate feedback*, focusing on what they do wrong and taking steps to fix them.
- They *repeat the process* over and over until they've reach their stretch target and the actions have become second-nature. Then, they set a new stretch goal and start over again.



KEY QUOTES

"Experts do it all over again, and again, and again. Until they have finally mastered what they set out to do. Until what was a struggle before is now fluent and flawless. Until conscious incompetence becomes unconscious competence."



Deliberate practice and grit. In a joint study of Spelling Bee contestants, Duckworth and Ericsson found that both grit and deliberate practice predicted spellers' performance. Deliberate practice was also much more effective than quizzes and reading for fun, in spellers' ability to advance to the next level.



Deliberate practice and flow. Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi found that people in a state of flow immerse themselves fully in their tasks to deliver high performance effortlessly and pleurably. Duckworth believes that deliberate practice hones your skill levels so you can perform even better when you're in flow:

- Deliberate practice is a set of behaviors (what experts *do*), while flow is an experience (how experts *feel*). Deliberate practice is about pushing yourself to improve *beyond* your existing skill levels (which makes it effortful and often unpleasant), while flow is about thriving at your *existing* skill level (which makes it enjoyable and effortless).
- Most of us see experts performing effortlessly in flow, but we don't see the years of deliberate practice that make their achievements possible in the first place.



Most people don't do deliberate practice *at all*. By understanding and applying the science of deliberate practice, you can increase your rate of learning significantly:

- Establish a routine for deliberate practice, doing it at the same time and place daily until it becomes a habit that you repeat without conscious thought.
- Seek to enjoy the challenge. Don't judge yourself during practice, as it only brings feelings of anxiety or self-blame.



Developing a Sense of Purpose



Purpose is "the intention to contribute to the well-being of others." Both gritty and non-gritty people seek short-term pleasures, but gritty people are drastically more likely to also seek to contribute to others. They usually spend years developing their skills and interest, *before* they discover their purpose later in life.



Similar to interests/passion, passion must be cultivated.

- Yale management professor Amy Wrzesniewski said that people can see their work as a job (a necessity to survive), a career (a stepping stone to better jobs), or a calling (a vital part of your life). Her research suggests that any type of work—regardless of its job description—could be a job, career or calling. It all depends on how you choose to see what you do.

KEY QUOTES

"Deliberate practice is for preparation, and flow is for performance."

"The idea of years of challenge-exceeding-skill practice leading to moments of challenge-meeting-skill flow explains why elite performance can look so effortless."

"If you keep practicing in the same time and place, what once took conscious thought to initiate becomes automatic."

"At its core, the idea of purpose is the idea that what we do matters to people other than ourselves."

"How you see your work is more important than your job title."

"The road to a purposeful, interesting passion was unpredictable."

- A sense of purpose emerges only with 2 key revelations: (i) you must discover a problem that needs solving (which may come as a revelation during a life event) and (ii) you must believe you can personally make a difference.



Here are 3 ways to start cultivating a sense of purpose:

- Connect your work with a bigger picture or vision. Constantly look at how you can make a positive impact with what you do.
- Find ways to tweak your work in small, meaningful ways to better express your personal values.
- Find a role model: study the life of people who inspire you, or imagine what'd matter most to you 15 years from now.



Nurturing Hope



Hope is “the expectation that our own efforts can improve our future”. It helps us to persevere; it gives us the strength to get up each time we fall and to keep going.

- Optimism. Everyone encounters setbacks. However, optimists are more likely to learn and find solutions because they attribute those setbacks to *temporary* and *specific causes* (e.g. “I made a mistake *this time*”). Pessimists are more likely to give up as they attribute the setbacks to *permanent* and *pervasive* causes (e.g. “I’m a loser”) which seem impossible to overcome.
- Our interpretation of events (and not the events themselves) determines our feelings and behaviors. By helping patients to think more objectively and healthily, cognitive behavioral therapists can address depression and related issues.
- According to psychologist Carol Dweck, people with growth mindsets believe that people can change (be it their skills, talents, or personality), while those with fixed mindsets think they can’t. Duckworth’s research shows that growth mindset and grit go hand in hand.



We can train ourselves to become more optimistic and gritty, by conditioning the prefrontal cortex of our brains to rationalize or moderate our fears.

KEY QUOTES

“Whatever your age, it’s never too early or late to begin cultivating a sense of purpose.”

“It isn’t suffering that leads to hopelessness. It’s suffering you think you can’t control.”

“When you keep searching for ways to change your situation for the better, you stand a chance of finding them. When you stop searching, assuming they can’t be found, you guarantee they won’t.”

“The reality is that most people have an inner fixed-mindset pessimist in them right alongside their inner growth-mindset optimist.”

- However, to do that, you must personally undergo challenges that you can control, to wire your neural circuits. Children and adolescents who experience adversity that they can control/influence are likely to become more resilient later in life. The more intense the experiences, the stronger the impact.
- Unfortunately, this also means that you can't talk someone into becoming grittier.



You can cultivate hope in several ways:

- Equip yourself with new facts and develop a growth mindset. Know that your brain is extremely flexible and gets stronger with use, just like your body's muscles. With practice, you can change anything from your intelligence to your skillsets. Each time you catch yourself responding with helplessness or frustration, step back and say "OK, I just slipped into a fixed mindset. Let's start over. What can we learn from this?"
- Practice optimistic self-talk and use growth-mindset language, e.g. "This is a tough problem that I can't solve yet" or "Great job! What did you learn to help you do even better?". Avoid fixed-mindset language, e.g. "This problem is too hard for me" or "Great job! You're a genius!".
- Ask for help. Having help and support gives you hope of improvement. Find role models who inspire you.

Developing Grit From Outside In



Parenting For Grit

Duckworth refers to parenting broadly as the act of nurturing the next generation. **Every grit paragon she interviewed had at least 1 person who, at the right time and in the right way, motivated him/her to push through to the next level.**



If you want your children to become grittier, you must first role model passion and perseverance in the pursuit of your own goals.



You can also use wise parenting—being concurrently supportive and demanding—to nurture grit.

KEY QUOTES

"Like a muscle that gets stronger with use, the brain changes itself when you struggle to master a new challenge."

"All of us are 'parents' to young people other than our own children in the sense that, collectively, we are responsible for 'bringing forth' the next generation."

- Unlike controlling parents, wise parents understand their children's psychological needs, and set rules/boundaries out of selflessness rather than a need for control. They don't always punish their kids for doing something wrong, nor do they let them get away with things. They respect their children's privacy and freedom, yet hold them accountable for their decisions.
- Wise parents set high expectations for their children backed by support. They enforce strict family rules which they themselves abide by. Kids with wise parents are more likely to emulate their parents' behaviors when they grow older.
- Teachers who're both supportive and demanding also tend to more positively impact their students. When teachers provide specific feedback and express their confidence in the students' ability to achieve high standards, the students are twice as likely to seek improvement.



Providing the Training Ground for Grit



Kids who participate in extra-curricular activities outside of the classroom tend to fare better from grades to self-esteem. Follow-through in such activities was found to be even more important—it was the best predictor of whether young people attained high achievement. Those who excelled later in life had (i) participated in ≥ 2 different high school extracurricular activities for several years each and (ii) made major advancements in both activities e.g. winning competitions or holding leadership roles.



Duckworth found grit and follow-through to be directly correlated. **When someone commits to an activity and makes progress in it over several years, it's a signal of their existing grit and at the same time shapes their character.** In scientific studies, animals and people who've done hard things in 1 area were found to be more tenacious in other hard tasks as well.



To nurture grit in young children:

- Sign them up for extra-curricular activities once they're old enough, so they spend at least some time each week doing hard things that interest them.
- Consider implementing the "Hard Thing Rule" in your family:

KEY QUOTES

"(Wise parents) appreciate that children need love, limits, and latitude to reach their full potential. Their authority is based on knowledge and wisdom, rather than power."

"Following through on our commitments while we grow up both requires grit and, at the same time, builds it."

- (i) Everyone (mum and dad included) must do a hard thing;
- (ii) Everyone gets to choose his/her hard thing; and
- (iii) You can only quit when you reach a natural stop point (e.g. at the end of a season or term) and not at your whim or fancy.



Developing a Culture of Grit



Culture refers to a group's shared norms and values. Our cultures shape our self-identity, worldview and how we think and act.



You can fast-track your grit development by joining a gritty culture.

- When you're surrounded by gritty people, you're likely to conform by becoming grittier. The cultural spillover effects can also create a "social multiplier effect" to multiply the overall grittiness of the group.
- Once you're shaped by a culture, the traits can become part of your self-identity and influence all your life decisions. For example, you may not push yourself to finish a triathlon due to a logical cost-benefit analysis, but you may do so out of the conviction that "I'm not a quitter".



To build a gritty culture, you'll need to communicate grit relentlessly in terms of what you say, how you say it, how often you say it, and how you demonstrate it. Communicate it to the point where everyone in the organization has internalized it.

Conclusion and Details in the Book to Look out For



Grit is a vital part of the psychology of success and how we manage ourselves. However, it's not the only virtue that's important. Our character is multi-dimensional, and there're other virtues (like social intelligence and curiosity) which affect how we interact with others, learn and engage with ideas.

In the book, Duckworth includes many other details, including:

- Empirical research, highlights of interviews with grit paragons, and examples of how people developed passion, purpose and perseverance in various fields

KEY QUOTES

"Whether we realize it or not, the culture in which we live, and with which we identify, powerfully shapes just about every aspect of our being."

"If you want to be grittier, find a gritty culture and join it."

"Either small environmental differences, or genetic ones, can trigger a virtuous cycle. Either way, the effects are multiplied socially, through culture, because each of us enriches the environment of all of us."

"The plurality of character operates against any one virtue being uniquely important."

"Grit isn't everything. There are many other things a person needs in order to grow and flourish. Character is plural."